cookhouse just above the company command post. The officer had by then realized that the attack was coming from the rear and was out in the open exhorting No. 5 Platoon to get out of the bunkers and face the rear. Burning kerosene and ghee tins cascaded down from the cookhouse, driving the officer back into his bunker where he was burnt alive, much to the horror of his watching troops.

After an hour, the shelling stopped. Anticipating a frontal assault on the heels of the mortar barrage, Charlie Company at Temporary Bridge began firing blindly across the Nam Ka Chu. The company commander, Major Sethi was nowhere to be seen and Second Lieutenant Onkar Dubey and Subedar Dashrath Singh had to calm down the nervous men. Recalled Dashrath: ‘There was a gap of some ten minutes or so when nothing was happening. All eyes were straining across the river, and no one was watching our rear. Suddenly, one could hear bugles and whistles on the slope behind us. It then dawned on me that the Chinese were behind us.’

Dashrath yelled at Naik Roshan to quickly move his section out of the defences and head for a prominent bump approximately 140 metres above the platoon’s position. As the men got there, out of breath, they could hear the Chinese forming up behind the rocky protrusion. Taking position on the moss-covered rock, Roshan and his men could see a teeming mass of Chinese troops, all bunched up, some forty metres in front of them. The section opened fire. It was the turn of the Chinese to be stunned as they took casualties, but the Chinese troops begun to surge downhill. The leading elements opened up with their AK-47 assault rifles and grenades, while from either side of the protrusion the Chinese troops poured past to attack Dashrath’s and Major Pant’s positions.

Pant had also realized that the direction of the attack was from the rear; he and Jemadar Bose yelled at the men to get out of the bunkers and prepare to meet the onslaught from the rear. Charlie Company’s No. 9 Platoon had barely enough time to pull itself out of the bunkers to face the rear. They could see Roshan’s men start firing, but then they were under fire themselves as the Chinese came down the slope, using the tree cover to steadily close the distance. Bursts of automatic fire were punctuated with the sharp retorts of .303 bolt-action Lee Enfield Rifles, LMGs; the choking smell of cordite from exploding grenades filled the air.

Every man in Roshan’s section held his ground against the sheer weight of the Chinese attack, and one by one, they died there. The few extra